

Overview

Between April and May 2026, Blueside Digital conducted independent WCAG 2.1 Level AA accessibility audits across more than 30 independent healthcare practice websites nationwide. Audits were conducted using the WAVE Web Accessibility Evaluation Tool by WebAIM, supplemented by manual structural review. Sites were scored using the AIM (Accessibility Index Measure) scale of 0-10.

Sites were selected based on the following criteria: independent or physician-owned practices with 15 or more employees accepting Medicare or Medicaid, with active public-facing websites in scope for WCAG 2.1 AA conformance obligations. The initiative coincided with the HHS Section 504 compliance window, subsequently extended via Interim Final Rule on May 7, 2026 to May 11, 2027.

Section 1: Critical Non-Compliance Findings

The following organizations were identified with significant WCAG 2.1 failures across structural errors, contrast failures, and assistive technology compatibility issues.

Specialty	Region	AIM	Errors	Contrast	Key Findings
Multi-specialty primary care	Mid-Atlantic, VA	2.5	85	19	83 empty links, missing alt text, missing form label
Cardiovascular	Mid-Atlantic, VA	4.7	22	8	5 missing form labels, 5 broken ARIA menus, patient portal non-compliant
Ophthalmology	Mid-Atlantic, VA	5.6	9	14	Scan error indicating screen reader incompatibility
Dermatology	Mid-Atlantic, VA	4.0	0	40	40 contrast failures, scan error suggesting DOM-level issues
Gastroenterology	New England, MA	4.0	5	86	86 contrast failures, missing form labels
Multi-specialty	Northeast, NY	5.2	13	16	9 empty links, missing form label, missing alt text
Multi-specialty primary care	Southwest, AZ	4.7	9	30	8 linked images missing alt text, empty button
Gastroenterology/Hepatology	Southeast, NC	1.3	57	184	45 empty links, 10 missing alt text, missing form label
Multi-specialty primary care	Southeast, FL	3.2	29	28	16 empty links, 10 missing alt text, scan error

Specialty	Region	AIM	Errors	Contrast	Key Findings
Dermatology	Midwest, OH/MI	3.0	33	28	31 missing alt text, empty link, missing form label
Oncology/Hematology	Midwest, MI	4.5	9	19	Structural navigation failures, missing form labels
Women's health	Southwest, TX	2.0	50	53	40 linked images missing alt text, missing form label
Nephrology/Endocrinology	Mountain West, NV	3.9	13	33	Empty buttons, empty links, missing form labels
Nephrology	Mid-Atlantic, MD	3.5	4	31	Missing alt text, linked images missing alt text, language attribute missing
Audiology/Hearing	Mid-Atlantic	4.8	8	27	Empty headings, empty links, contrast failures
Oncology	Southeast, NC	4.2	14	22	Empty links, missing form labels, ARIA issues
Internal Medicine	Mid-Atlantic, NC	4.8	0	33	Contrast failures throughout
Multi-specialty	Mid-Atlantic, VA	6.2	2	15	Missing form label, missing alt text, contrast failures

Section 2: Significant Findings - Contact Unavailable

The following sites demonstrated significant WCAG 2.1 failures but decision-maker contacts could not be identified through available research methods.

Specialty	Region	AIM	Errors	Contrast	Key Findings
Gastroenterology network	Mid-Atlantic, PA/DE	3.5	24	26	19 empty links, missing form label, missing alt text. Active data breach notice on homepage.
Multi-specialty primary care	New England, MA	3.3	3	94	94 contrast failures, empty links. Site tagline: 'Making High-Quality Healthcare Accessible for All.'
Primary care	Northeast, RI	3.4	14	43	13 empty links, missing form label, contrast failures.
Orthopedic	Mid-Atlantic, VA	4.5	8	27	Empty headings, empty buttons, empty links, contrast failures.
Cardiology	Southwest, AZ	3.8	0	51	51 contrast failures, scan error. Data security incident banner on homepage.

Section 3: Contrast-Only Failures

The following sites presented primarily contrast-ratio failures without significant structural WCAG errors. All sites remain non-compliant with the WCAG 2.1 AA color contrast requirement of 4.5:1 minimum ratio for normal text.

Specialty	Region	AIM	Errors	Contrast	Notes
Cardiovascular	Southeast	3.8	0	51	Scan error alongside 51 contrast failures
Internal Medicine	Mid-Atlantic	4.8	0	33	Pure contrast failures, no structural errors
Orthopedic	Southeast, FL	5.3	0	18	Contrast only, borderline score
Gastroenterology	Southeast	5.8	5	12	Minimal errors, contrast dominant
Multi-specialty	Southeast	6.2	2	15	Near-compliant but contrast failures present

Section 4: Compliant Sites

Approximately 25% of sites audited demonstrated strong WCAG 2.1 compliance, confirming that conformance is achievable at the independent practice level without a full redesign.

Specialty	Region	AIM Score	Status	Notes
Gastroenterology	Mid-Atlantic, VA	9.0	Compliant	WCAG 2.1 AA conformant
Internal Medicine/Rheumatology	Mid-Atlantic, VA	9.9	Compliant	Best score observed across all audits
Multi-specialty	Mid-Atlantic, MD	8.9	Compliant	Strong compliance
Orthopedic	Southeast	7.9	Compliant	Above threshold, minor alerts only
Women's health	Mid-Atlantic, VA	8.1	Compliant	Strong compliance
Dermatology	Southeast	8.6	Compliant	Above threshold
Cardiovascular	Southeast	8.0	Compliant	Above threshold
Multi-specialty	Midwest	7.5	Compliant	Above threshold
Primary care	Southeast	7.9	Compliant	Above threshold

Key Findings

Average AIM Score across non-compliant sites: 3.7 out of 10

No site in the critical findings category achieved a passing score. Several fell below 2.0.

Most Common WCAG 2.1 Failures

- Empty anchor elements (present in 14 of 18 critical sites) - breaks screen reader navigation entirely
- Missing programmatic form labels (present in 15 of 18) - patient portals and appointment forms inaccessible to assistive technology
- Images missing alternative text (present in 11 of 18) - visually impaired patients cannot navigate image-based links
- Insufficient color contrast (present across all non-compliant sites) - fails the 4.5:1 minimum ratio for normal text
- JavaScript synchronization errors (present in 6 sites) - indicates likely screen reader incompatibility at the DOM level

Notable Observations

- Two sites displayed active data security incident notices alongside significant accessibility failures
 - One practice with the tagline 'Making High-Quality Healthcare Accessible for All' scored 3.3 AIM with 94 contrast failures
 - The most severe finding was a gastroenterology practice scoring 1.3 AIM with 57 errors and 184 contrast failures
 - 25% of audited sites demonstrated strong compliance, confirming WCAG 2.1 AA conformance is achievable without a full redesign
-

Compliance Context

The HHS Office for Civil Rights published a final rule in 2024 establishing WCAG 2.1 Level AA as the enforceable digital accessibility standard for healthcare organizations receiving federal funding under Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act. The initial compliance deadline of May 11, 2026 was extended via Interim Final Rule on May 7, 2026 to May 11, 2027 for organizations with 15 or more employees.

The extension does not eliminate compliance obligations or pause enforcement authority. HHS Office for Civil Rights retains the ability to investigate proactively. ADA litigation targeting healthcare web accessibility has been increasing year over year regardless of regulatory deadlines.

Remediation Approach

The most critical failures identified are code-level fixes that do not require visual redesign. Specifically:

- Empty links: Adding descriptive aria-label attributes or visible link text

- Missing form labels: Adding programmatic label elements or aria-labelledby associations
- Missing alt text: Adding descriptive alt attributes to img elements
- Contrast failures: CSS color value adjustments to meet the 4.5:1 ratio threshold
- Broken ARIA: Correcting malformed role and aria-controls attributes on navigation components

None of these remediations require changes to layout, branding, or conversion flows. The site's visual appearance remains intact. The underlying structure becomes accessible.

About Blueside Digital

Blueside Digital is an independent digital engineering consultancy specializing in regulated industries including healthcare, pharma, and federal government. Core competencies include WCAG 2.1 / Section 508 accessibility compliance, full-stack web development, and enterprise CMS platforms including WordPress, Drupal, and Adobe Experience Manager.

cashwell.digital@gmail.com

bluesidedigital.com